

ENTERTAINMENT

A NEW ENEMY AT THE GATE

Pakistan-bashing has long been a favourite subject in Bollywood films. The industry is now mining the rich history of Indo-China conflict for inspiration

By ***SUHANI SINGH***

Rajneesh Ghai grew up in the quaint little town of Wellington in Tamil Nadu listening to stories of inspiring battles from his father, Lieutenant Colonel L.T. Ghai. One tale particularly, from the 1962 Indo-Sino War, blew him away. It recounted the heroics of the 13th battalion of the Kumaon regiment in which 120 soldiers, led by Major Shaitaan Singh, faced 3,000 Chinese soldiers and killed more than a third. It came to be known as the Battle of Rezang La, part of a war in which India lost lives, territory and morale, but demonstrated the valour of its jawans.

120 Bahadur, the recent David-vs-Goliathesque film starring Farhan Akhtar as Major Singh, is the result of Ghai's lifelong fascination. "The sacrifice and bravery of these men," says Ghai, director of the film, "was such that I felt it had to be told to the country." His brother, Lieutenant General Rajiv Ghai, Director General of Military Operations, gave him an elaborate account of the battle, which he supplemented with two years of research that included interviews with surviving soldiers Ram Chandar Singh and Nihal Singh